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**Regressive Repose: Media and Instant Gratification in Ottessa Moshfegh's
My Year of Rest and Relaxation (2018)**

الراحة التراجعية: الإعلام والإشباع الفوري في رواية أوتيسا موشفيغ
"سنة الراحة والاسترخاء" (2018)

Dr- Chabira Hanane

University of Mustapha Stambouli Mascara- Algeria.

hanane.chabira@univ-mascara.dz

دّة / شبيرة حنان

جامعة مصطفى إسمطنبولي معسكر – الجزائر

hanane.chabira@univ-mascara.dz

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Abstract:

Otessa Moshfegh's novel *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* (2018) provides a scathing critique of a media-saturated society through the perspective of a nameless protagonist seeking a yearlong "hibernation" relying on pharmaceuticals and mindless media entertainment. This article examines the novel using Neil Postman's theories in *Amusing Ourselves to Death* (1985), wherein he argues that contemporary media prioritises entertainment over substantive discourse, resulting in a mass cultural erosion. Through the lens of the protagonist's addiction to television, VCRs, and prescription drugs, this study posits that Moshfegh's novel effectively illustrates Postman's insights about the resultant dangers and perils of instant gratification. The novel's satirical comments on alienation and apathy serve as a mirror for a broader cultural trend towards triviality found in Postman's ideology of media ecology. This article's findings highlight the importance of Postman's analysis in comprehending the commodification of experiences as well as cultural deterioration through media studies and literary analysis.

Keywords: Culture, Pharmaceuticals, Instant Gratification, Media, Entertainment,

المخلص:

تقدم رواية "عام من الراحة والاسترخاء" (2018) للكاتبة أوتيسا موشفغ نقدًا لاذعًا لمجتمع مشبع بوسائل الإعلام من خلال منظور بطل مجهول الهوية. يريد أن "يسبت" لمدة عام معتمدًا على الأدوية ووسائل الترفيه الإعلامية الطائشة. تتناول هذه المقالة أدناه الرواية من منظور نيل بوستمان في كتابه "تسليية أنفسنا حتى الموت" (1985)، والذي يناقش فيه أن وسائل الإعلام المعاصرة تعطي الأولوية للترفيه على النقاش الموضوعي، مما يؤدي إلى تدهور ثقافي جماعي. من خلال وجهة نظر إدمان بطل الرواية على التلفاز وأجهزة الفيديو والعقاقير الطبية، تفترض هذه الدراسة أن رواية موشفغ توضح بشكل فعال رؤى بوستمان حول المخاطر والمخاطر الناتجة عن الإشباع الفوري. كما أن تعليقات الرواية الساخرة على الاغتراب واللامبالاة هي بمثابة مرآة لاتجاه ثقافي أوسع نحو التفاهة الموجودة في أيديولوجية بوستمان حول بيئة وسائل الإعلام. تسلط النتائج التي توصل إليها هذا المقال الضوء على أهمية تحليل بوستمان في فهم قضية تسليع التجارب وكذلك التدهور الثقافي من خلال الدراسات الإعلامية والتحليل الأدبي.

الكلمات المفتاحية: الثقافة، الأدوية، الإشباع الفوري، الإعلام، الترفيه .

1. INTRODUCTION

In the wake of the collective alienation crisis of 2019 caused by the COVID-19 pandemic, *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* by Otessa Moshfegh, published in 2018, has gained significance among readers, mainly due to its immense popularity in social media reading communities, for its specific political and social context as both a cultural document and an eerily prophetic allegory. Following up on her parents' deaths, Otessa

Moshfegh's protagonist embarks on a Sisyphean attempt to hibernate her way out of depression, offering a subtle commentary on the futility of seeking rest through self-isolation and escapism. On a more micro level, the novel provides a judicious critique of the era's zeitgeist, with a particular emphasis on the consumer cultural milieu of 2000s New York through its representation of different faces of postmodern archetypes. From the hedonistic pursuit of pleasure to the

desperate search for identity and solace, the novel's characters embody the anxieties and discontent of a society irreversibly moulded by consumerism and media oversaturation.

Published in 1985, Neil Postman's seminal work *Amusing Ourselves to Death* offers an insightful critique of the transformative nature of media in reorienting modern society into a trivialised and entertainment-driven dystopia. According to Postman's perspective, the radical shift from print media to televised media has undermined serious and critical discourse in favour of supplementing superficial pleasure and the pursuit of instant gratification. Drawing his analysis from Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World*, Postman concludes that oppression in modern societies is no longer bound to the traditional external tyrannical dynamics; rather, it is implemented through submitting the masses, subliminally and explicitly, into mindless amusement and distraction. In *My Year of Rest and Relaxation*, the narrator of the novel represents a microcosm of the aforementioned phenomena, as her reliance on pharmaceuticals to gratify her need to escape reality mirrors the collective sedation Postman describes. Analysing the novel's characters through Postman's enquiries and critical lens permits one to uncover the protagonist's quest for instant gratification through sleeping, which results not in her happiness but in a mental spiral.

2. Media Ecology and the Tyranny of Entertainment

Media have always had a pivotal role in directing conversation and facilitating communication among the masses. In Tony Schwartz's words, it serves as an aperture into the world and a gateway to the mind. It offers understanding to unveil previously unacknowledged reality (Schwartz, 1983, p.

2). However, the metamorphosis of print media to a visual and electronic one has shifted the tide from deep rational cultural discourse into mere meaningless hollow echoes. In this light, Neil Postman's *Amusing Ourselves to Death* presents an in-depth analysis of television's ability to dismantle human mental capacity and confine it to entertainment.

2.1. The Travilisation and Commodification of Postmodern Culture

According to Postman, television, with its hyperfixation of colourful images and brevity, has impacted information processing progress. In this, he writes, "a news show, to put it plainly, is a format for entertainment, not for education, reflection or catharsis" (Postman, 1985, p. 87). The pleasant music, colourful setting, and attractive physical appeal of the presenters create a dramatised and show-like effect on news that reduces literacy and critical thinking, leading to an informed yet unknowledgeable public. Analogically, Postman uses Las Vegas as a symbol for late capitalist American culture, which is heavily focused on entertainment. He argues, "all public discourse increasingly takes the form of entertainment" (Postman, 1985, p. 3), leading us to a point where we are "slowly amusing ourselves to death" (Postman, 1985, p. 4). We see the impact everywhere. In politics, debates are more about catchy remarks and exaggerated tantrums than real policies. News stories are often exaggerated to grab the audience's attention rather than to truly inform us. This postmodern culture puts more value on feelings than on thinking and on instant reactions rather than thoughtful reflection.

Additionally, other postmodern writers such as Baudrillard and Jameson have analysed how commodities work in a media-

saturated world. Baudrillard examines the overflow of images and how a society focused on imitation has developed, similar to the postmodern culture that Postman describes. Jean Baudrillard, in his seminal work *The Consumer Society: Myths and Structure*, believes that mass communications and media, small news stories reveal their sad hypocrisy. They contrast the calmness of our everyday lives with signs of disaster, deaths, murders, rapes, and revolutions. According to Baudrillard, media messages are a collage of fabricated and orchestrated signs that are meticulously manufactured to create a balance between “the discourse of ‘news’ [information] and the discourse of ‘consumption’” (Baudrillard, 1998, p. 121). By interweaving advertisement along with the news, the audience is placed in an untenable position where the line between real news, i.e. “reality” and the capitalist propaganda of consumerism becomes blurred, thus creating an illusion of reality and dissolving the importance of meaning. In fact, Baudrillard pushed this argument further, asserting that the postmodern world is “more and more information, and less and less meaning” (Baudrillard, 1994, p. 55). In that sense, society is overwhelmed with an abundance of information, yet people’s sense of comprehension diminishes. Real events are replaced with simulations, and political and ideological notions become disentangled from their initial informative role into mediated cultural diversions.

This profusion of artificial culture, accompanied by a hegemonisation of commodity production, has ushered in a society wherein advertising and hyperconsumption are the new cultural ideology. In *Signatures of the Visible*, Frederick Jameson writes that culture appears

as “the very element of consumer society itself; no society has ever been saturated with signs and messages like this one” (Jameson, 1992, p. 139). This argument is central to outlining the connection between media messages and their involvement with the commodification of culture and the glorification of fleeting pleasures. Fuelled by a plethora of endless and instantaneous advertisements, media has created an illusionary version of the “ideal life” and “ideal person”, an aestheticised reality that can only be achieved through the utmost acquirement of material possessions. This manipulative strategy, refined by mass media, has generated an artificial necessity and yearning to supplant the vacuity it has engendered. Consequently, for the postmodern individual, existential significance is attenuated, necessitating an assimilation into prevailing cultural norms and the acquisition of proffered commodities to compensate for an internal void.

2.2 The Allure of Instant Gratification

As previously mentioned, postmodern society is first and foremost a consumer-driven culture, one that is premised upon pleasure-seeking and material possession acquisition; more so, the essential act of purchasing and consuming is often met with an instant sense of gratification because it is easy, effortless, and quick. From a psychological standpoint, instant gratification is defined as a response mechanism that “is driven by the brain's reward system, where the release of dopamine, a neurotransmitter associated with pleasure and reward, reinforces behaviors that lead to satisfying outcomes” (Brook & Santons, 2023, p.1). This complex response could manifest in a variety of ways, including making impulsive purchases. Although pursuing instant gratification might bring

about momentary happiness and excitement, it can also negatively impact long-term objectives and overall well-being.

Particularly through the prism of media culture, the appeal of instant gratification becomes a fundamental criticism of modern media's impact on society from Neil Postman's perspective. Postman contends that the transition from a typography culture to a media one has transformed human emotional investment, embracing pleasure and perpetuating critical decline. Media's magnetic pull presents a "variety of subject matter, requires minimal skills to comprehend it, and is largely aimed at emotional gratification" (Postman, 1985, p. 86). This argument is further elaborated, as Postman believes that now the masses are subjected to "spiritual devastation" that comes from an "enemy with a smiling face". This "smiling face" is a reflection of television's seductive immediacy, which offers quick, easily absorbed enjoyment with little effort on the part of the viewer, in contrast to reading's requirement for introspection. Instant gratification's ability to avoid the drawn-out, difficult process of critical reasoning and instead offer a seemingly effortless and infinite sensory experience is what makes it so alluring. Postman continues, suggesting that the quest for fleeting pleasure has weakened meaningful conversation, leaving just a surface-level exchange of spectacle where people no longer talk to each other but rather entertain each other (Postman, 1985, p. 92). He concludes that this phenomenon is dangerous in addition to being a cultural shift because it teaches people to value speed and accessibility over depth and complexity, undermining the intellectual rigour necessary for a good functional society. Therefore, entertainment can be considered stimulant

currency for instant gratification.

It is worth noting that gratification is not necessarily exclusive to shopping; it is connected to any activity that brings a satisfactory and rewarding reaction to the human brain. According to Paul Roberts, the idea of a personalised existence, which is based on each person's needs and preferences, has not only earned endorsement but has also become a standard in modern society (Roberts, 2014, p. 6). As Roberts' remark illustrates, this personalisation also exists in the context of feelings, where people are depending increasingly on pharmaceuticals to regulate and alter their emotions. A larger cultural drive towards instant gratification and an appetite for dominance over all facets of life, both subjective and internal, is reflected in the dependency on medications to ameliorate emotional experiences. This obsession with medicines, therapy, and well-being did not magically plague postmodern society; there is ongoing propaganda that puts people under pressure to work on themselves. Capitalism has conjured up this narrative, under the guise of having a better world that people need to first fix themselves. Unsurprisingly, this can be achieved through consuming all variants of pharmaceuticals, which ultimately boosts capitalist enterprises. Yet, there would not be a need to cure oneself if it were not for the capitalist dire conditions. Pertaining to this matter, Jean Baudrillard asserts that "medicine and doctors have a cultural virtue rather than a therapeutic function, and they are consumed as 'virtual' mana" (Baudrillard, 1998, p. 140). This "cultural virtue" that Baudrillard attributes to medicine and doctors implies that they are seen as possessing a kind of social and moral authority and that they are sought after not just for their ability to cure illness but also for

their symbolic value as agents of healing and well-being.

It may be opined then that media fulfils two primary purposes in addition to being a source of instant gratification, by its pervasive influence, it also shapes societal norms and individual conduct. On one hand, it serves as an external stimulus, presenting individuals with a constant flow of readily available content that is effortless to engage with. As mentioned previously, Postman accentuates how media's accessibility and pervasiveness, whether through dazzling advertisements or news segments, reduces the cognitive effort necessary of its audience. In this manner, Marshall McLuhan claims that the "cool" factor of television, which "requires very little participation from the viewer" (McLuhan, 1964, p. 31), lies at the core of this convenience in consumption. It leads the public into a state of apathy where rapid sensory gratification takes precedence over deeper introspection. Expanding on this idea, according to Alan M. Rubin's research entitled "The Interactions of Television Uses and Gratifications", viewers confine themselves to television "for pass time - habit, information, escape, and entertainment reasons" (Rubin, 1981, p. 10), favouring immediate comfort above ongoing engagement. This results in a toxic reliance on media as a quick boredom treatment. Furthermore, media actively encourages and establishes the pursuit of immediate satisfaction by its message and content, which produces an alluring paradigm in which demands are met immediately and without repercussions. According to Jennings Bryant and Dolf Zillmann, individuals are now watching and accepting television "for the excitement of it" (Bryant & Zillmann, 1984, p. 4), which fosters viewers to despise delayed rewards, produces unrealistic

expectations. A cycle of reinforcement is created by such marketing. In other words, consumers who are conditioned to anticipate instant gratification are increasingly turning to the media for satisfaction, which increases their reliance on its easy appeal. As Postman concludes, this loop gradually erodes patience and critical thinking, leaving society "amusing [itself] to death" (Postman, 1985, p. 163) in a never-ending quest for the next quick but fleeting acme.

3. Sedation and Screens: Dissecting *My Year of Rest and Relaxation*

Since its publication in 2018, *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* has sparked a plethora of critical recognitions. The novel is highly praised for its brilliant sociohistorical interplay and ability to provide "a comment and analysis of both the late '90s and of 2016–2018" (Saramandi), thus accentuating its timelessness. While the novel garnered acclaim and enthusiastic reception among both Millennial and Generation Z readers, it has inescapably encountered censure for its incessant references to "eating disorders, abusive relationships, toxic friendships, sexual abuse, drug misuse, and so much more" (Kavvada). It can be argued that Moshfegh's writing technique and style are heavily influenced by the 1990s Blank Fiction genre. Coined by James Annesley in 1998, the term 'Blank Fiction' refers to a literary style that not only mirrors its historical moment but also adopts the commodified, detached language of its era as a narrative voice (Annesley, 1998, p. 7). To expemplify, authors such as Bret Easton Ellis, Jay McInerney, and Tama Janowitz conjured up their narratives by excessively threading meticulous descriptions of consumer products, pop-culture references, and the obscenity of the late capitalist metropolis scene. In this light, Moshfegh's novel can be

seen as both a descendant of and a continuation of this tradition, adapting its tools to explore contemporary consumer alienation in relation to the postmodern one. Moshfegh's novel is a satirical portrait of media-saturated postmodernity, where the characters' reliance on pills, television, and pop-culture obsession mirrors the cultural critique of Neil Postman and his postmodern contemporaries.

3.1. A World of Spectacle and Mainstream

My Year of Rest and Relaxation follows the pre-9/11 chronicles of an unnamed WASP female New Yorker. The novel by no means delineates any eventful traditional storyline; it simply narrates the protagonist's monotonous quotidian existence, which she tries to navigate through prolonged periods of sleep. Following the deaths of both of her parents, she resorts to an eclectic melange of pharmaceuticals that are prescribed by ethically dubious psychiatrist Dr. Tuttle. While the protagonist's medical addiction is a central thread of her narrative trajectory, it often obscures a deeper yet more insidious, subtle addiction: television. Moshfegh's characters have a rooted interconnectedness between their personal lives and pop culture, a nexus evident through the conceptualisation of their individuality and reality within a technological matrix. Their perception of reality and identity, mediated and conditioned by the media's omnipresence, reveals a profound apprehension about the real world outside of the media's confinement, precluding the construction of a distinctive personal reality of their own.

The novel operates in two interwoven layers of narrative, each accentuating distinct yet symbiotic facets of the characters' discontent. The first surface layer revolves around the protagonist's relentless quest for

self-induced semi-coma, an act of withdrawal that parallels the lethargy induced by her media consumption. The second layer gouges a penetrating consumerism discourse, projected by media. Central to this media existence is the protagonist's idiosyncratic hyperfixation on the actress Whoopie Goldberg, whom she considers a hero because "[she] seemed like an absurd interloper on the U.S.S. Enterprise. Whenever she appeared on-screen, I sensed she was laughing at the whole production," and "everything around her became a parody of itself, gauche and ridiculous" (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 195-196). In that sense, she perceives Goldberg as her idol and even inspiration for her aversion to introspection. While she is obsessed with Goldberg and owns VHS copies of all her works, this admiration does not stem from the actress's talent or artistic range; rather, she points out that she does not watch her movies "The Colour Purple" and "Ghost", for they are too sad and too emotionally gravitating. This selective approach implies a deeper psychological imperative, her need for a quick surge of happiness and gratification cannot be interrupted by any deep analysis or contemplation. Postman's perspective sharpens this insight as he warns that the media's constant coercion for amusement diminishes inner reflection, altering the concept of self-interest and reducing our experiences to a "form of therapy" rather than a vessel for actual meaning (Postman, 1985, p. 135). Therefore, the protagonists' hyperfixation on Goldberg resonates with this ethos; an actress who, in accordance with the protagonist's desire to circumvent the burden of sincere feeling, uses subversive humour to reduce reality to a parody.

Interestingly, this favouritism of superficiality over depth is further articulated

in a broader view, where laxity and familiarity trump novelty. The protagonist admits that although she can watch several movies or any movie that she wants, she always opts for Harrison Ford and Whoopie Goldberg because they are familiar, and “the stupider the movie, the less my mind had to work” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 72). This confession crystallises her allegiance to media as an analgesic, a strategy to hinder any possible cognitive effort while ensuring easy consumption. This aligns with Postman’s critique of American television specifically as a medium that alters the structure of discourse by promoting specific forms of intellect by offering a myriad of subjects that require minimal intellectual participation and foster emotional gratification (Postman, 2018, p. 86). The protagonist's choice of “stupid films” is a conscious decision that reflects what Baudrillard explains as the American’s tendency to “refuge in the tranquillity of the easy life, in a triumphal illusionism” (Baudrillard, 1988, p. 104). The contrast between her rejection of *The Colour Purple*, a story condensed with racial and gendered complexity, and her love of Goldberg's lighter roles further indicates a failure to address and face reality. Under this interpretation, her medium intake seems to be both a symptom and a potential cause of her semi-coma, a simultaneous addiction that strengthens the novel's condemnation of a society consumed by its pleasures.

At a cursory examination, the protagonist’s preoccupation with media and its representations can be interpreted as a natural extension of her affluent lifestyle and upper-class milieu. Nevertheless, by introducing Reva, a woman from a working-class background, the protagonist’s frenemy, Moshfegh, intricately complicates this

superficial interpretation, emphasising the inexorable manipulation of media through different social strata. Whilst Reva self-identifies as an “underprivileged” person, she is paradoxically endowed with an extensive encyclopaedic knowledge about pop culture, as she “knew all the latest celebrity gossip and follows the newest fashion trends” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 13). Reva’s cultural fluency is often met with the protagonist's unrelenting criticism, which ridicules her concern with tabloids and beauty standards—a critique that reveals a hypocritical involvement in the same media-saturated world, albeit disguised as ironic detachment. This duality invites interrogation of the media's pervasive existence, highlighting desperate reactions shaped by status and agency. While the protagonist rejects her reality by retreating to the comfort of media, Reva is fully aware of media manipulation, and she embraces it with its faults as an assimilation mechanism to “fit in .”

Therefore, the question of social status plays a vital role in that the protagonist has the luxury to afford an escapist lethargy while Reva refrains from following the same path; thus, the only way she can conform is to adopt and strive to achieve social standards. It is through brand shopping, countless spas, getting skinny, being pretty, and emulating the upper-class mannerisms that she can compensate for her feelings of class inferiority. All these strategies to conform and gain inner gratification are a direct outcome of the media's constant encouragement to search for happiness through material acquisition. The protagonist argues that despite following the supposed routine of finding fulfilment, as she addresses : “I go colonics and facials and highlights, worked out at an overpriced gym, lay in the hammam there until I went blind”

(Moshfegh, 2018, p. 28), she still could not find the lasting enjoyment that she was promised. Zygmunt Bauman explains this unachievable satisfaction as the “consumerist syndrome”, which is premised upon “speed, excess, and waste” (Bauman, 2007, p. 86). Interestingly, Reva is devoted to self-help books and courses that generally mixed some new dieting method with professional development and love relationship skills, under the premise of educating young women on how to maximise their potential (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 15). Relating to this, Jean Baudrillard contends that media and advertisement have effectively separated the body as an entity of consumption by creating an obsession with the idea of perfect bodies; it has now become an object of solicitude that can only be satisfied through possessing objects (Baudrillard, 1998, p. 141). This kind of self-help books and beauty regime does not truly work to help women; the human mind is in constant search for gratification and fulfilment, and capitalists propagandise on this nexus by creating problems that can only be solved by buying guides, services, and products to mend these same manufactured problems.

3.2. Pharmaceuticals as Instant Escape

Heretofore, instant gratification has been chiefly discussed in terms of material possessions and media manipulation to foster this type of satisfaction. However, in essence, *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* is a punctilious documentation of the protagonist’s attempt to numb reality by utilising a pharmacopoeia of antidepressants, anxiolytics, and sedatives, not for therapeutic purposes but as premeditated instruments to eliminate the exigencies of unmediated existence. Throughout the novel, there is a striking correlation between her immersion in television and her use of pills, both serving as

twin conduits for escaping reality and seeking solace in satisfaction and quick fixes. This duality is manifested in her admission, “I watched movies and ate animal crackers and took trazodone and Ambien and Nembutal until I fell asleep again. I lost track of time in this way” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 1). Together, these mechanisms created a comfortable cocoon, shielding her from the contingencies of a world teetering on the brink of 9/11 upheaval.

From a psychoanalytical vantage, Sigmund Freud argues in *Civilization and Its Discontents* that “Men know that with the help [of intoxicants] they can get from drowning their cares they can at any time slip away from the oppression of reality and find a refuge in a world of their own where painful feelings do not enter” (Freud, 2010, p. 78). This diagnosis heavily resonates with the protagonist’s crusade to avoid feeling anything at all (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 204). Her obsessive pill-taking—Ambien to promote sleep, Trazodone to reduce anxiety, and Nembutal to increase oblivion—reflects Freud’s portrayal of medications as a transient bulwark against the “control” of her parents’ deaths that she needs to be liberated from and the impending instability of the postmodern world. This psychoanalytical perspective gains further nuance when considering the protagonist’s education and employment background. She majored in art history and briefly worked as an art dealer’s assistant at an art gallery. According to Freud, art is a form of substitutive gratification. He argues that while indeed art can be a source of pleasure, it is merely “a mild narcotic and can provide no more than a temporary refuge for us from the hardships of life” (Freud, 2010, p. 81), a concept that initially seems to reflect her educational and professional endeavours.

The protagonist aspired to be an artist but lacked the necessary talent for the craft. Yet, she still clung to art as a form of salvation from her misery, a solution thwarted, as art became “like a stock market, a reflection of political trends and the persuasions of capitalism, fueled by greed and gossip and cocaine” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 183). This disillusionment signifies an important milestone in her life: art, which previously offered sublimation—a Freudian process of transforming suffering into artistic expression—now reflects the commercialised and commodified superficiality she tries to avoid, propelling her in the direction of more potent distractions. Her outright dismissal of the transformative and redemptive possibilities that art possesses ultimately drives her to seek refuge in various forms of media and the consumption of illicit substances, which offer immediate comfort without necessitating the laborious processes of interpretation or the creative act of production. Indeed, she candidly acknowledges her preference for a state of emotional numbness, indicating her willingness to forgo any feelings whatsoever. Consequently, Moshfegh meticulously constructs a narrative framework that unveils the protagonist's acquiescence to a reality wherein suffering cannot be alleviated or improved but is instead forsaken, and this is poignantly illustrated through the juxtaposition of the squandered potential inherent in artistic expression against the compelling allure of chemical intoxication.

To further elucidate the protagonist's reliance on drugs and how this dependency is an unactualised way to escape, Reva, her friend who is bulimic and whose relationship issues mirror the protagonist's ones in a counterproductive way. Both are self-destructive and desperate to escape what they

have become, but they differ in how they pursue escape, as well as why they do: the protagonist's immediate goal is gratification in annihilation, not confrontation. Conversely, Reva's bulimia represents a physical and corporeal act of rebellion against her social background, a desperate attempt to purge not just food but the emotional weight of an affair with a married man, her insecurities and the pressure to maintain an idealised image. Her coping mechanism is erratic and periodic, typified by bingeing on cheap food and purging it, which mirrors the frenzy of her external situation, a line that captures her desperate, a physical effort to wrest need from a life that careened out of her control. This corporeal engagement with her suffering is clearly at odds with the protagonist's intellectual retreat into a pharmacologically induced stupor. Reva's bulimia comes at her distress actively, if destructively, projecting outwards through her own body; the protagonist's pill regimen is passive and internal, a systematised numbing of her being that aims rather to erase herself than to interact with it. This divergence heightens the protagonist's choice of oblivion over agency; her addiction to Ambien, Trazodone and Nembutal is unregulated, and each dosage amounts to a step toward a near-catatonic state wherein reality cannot intrude. According to Bauman, even if drugs were working, “the satisfaction would not last long, since in the world of the consumers possibilities are infinites” (Bauman, 2000, p. 72), this would explain her resorting to Infermitrol, which causes her sleepwalking psychosis. Whereas Reva cannot escape the urgency of her body's needs, her bulimia, though it brings brief release, is perpetually attached to the visceral and temporal; she has to deal with the aftermath of every purge, with the

exhaustion, with the shame, with the upending of hunger. The protagonist's pharmaceutical cocoon, made possible through her privilege and isolation, protects her from that endlessness, providing a malevolent and smooth descent into nothingness that Reva's periodic purges can never offer.

3.2. Reflections of a Hollow Culture

In *My Year of Rest and Relaxation*, there is a concerted use of television and media as a pervasive agent in the fragmentation of the characters' life trajectories, an accelerant to their toxic lifestyles through a relentless deluge of staccato, shallow stimuli. These mediums are not agents of decay, per se, but serve rather as symptomatic shards of a prismatic flag of a weak and hollow monument to a passive audience to the hyperreal. Every line and context in Ottessa Moshfegh's novel is a reminder of this hollow culture, one where real experience is exchanged for a thin coat of commodified distraction and ongoing collective existential detachment. Jean Baudrillard's theory of hyperreality sheds light on this perspective, asserting that images can be used to "mask[] the absence of a profound reality" (Baudrillard, 1994, p. 4) and that contemporary society "has no relation to any reality whatsoever" (Baudrillard, 1994, p. 4), where signs and simulations, televised images, advertisements, and news snippets eclipse the tangible world. This is apparent when the protagonists are "[at] a loss for how to handle reality", a reality where "a Harlem teenager had thrown her newborn baby down a sewage drain. A mine caved in somewhere in South America" (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 104). These catastrophic events, laden with people's suffering, are juxtaposed with the banal cultural optimism of "Mariah Carey [giving]

Christmas gifts to orphans in the Dominican Republic" (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 104), a jarring dissonance that reduces tragedy into a hyperreal pastiche, devoid of emotional weight or a decent moral compass.

This superficiality is heightened by the endless advertisements that punctuate her watching habits, a sign of a world in which meaning has been subordinated to consumption. Television is oversaturated with advertisements ranging from commercials for cat food, commercial home saunas, and potato chips to a commercial about how "Coca-Cola means "I love you"" (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 197), a list of minutiae that overwhelms the protagonist's mind. This could be analysed through a Baudrillardian perspective, as he asserts

Today what we are experiencing is the absorption of all virtual modes of expression into that of advertising. All original cultural forms, all determined languages are absorbed in advertising because it has no depth, it is instantaneous and instantaneously forgotten. Triumph of superficial form, of the smallest common denominator of all signification. (Baudrillard, 1994, p. 61)

Far from disguising a more fundamental truth, these commercials are the reality, and reality is produced as a knot of hyperreal interwoven cultural signifiers that eradicate any distinction between need or want, profundity or tedium. The characters' unresisting consumption of this media barrage is, in fact, a capitulation to this empty culture, which uses television not as a window to the world but as a reflection of its own vacuousness.

It is imperative to recognise that this shallowness transcends the realm of the

characters' lifestyle, composing the structure of their interpersonal relationships and connections as human beings. This vacuity is not a mere peripheral trait but a consistent element that filters the protagonist's interactions; it is manifested throughout different stages of the protagonist's life, from her damaged ties with her late parents, her transactional relationship with Dr. Tuttle, and her toxic friendship with Reva. Each interaction acts as a microcosm of this communal deterioration, illustrating the protagonist's—and by extension, her milieu's—inability to create genuine relationships in a landscape driven by passiveness, consumerism, and vanity. This relational emptiness, stemming from emotional distance and inner disconnection, alludes to a larger cultural malaise, where real connections are traded for imitation of intimacy that mirrors the fractured hyperrealism that pervades the novel. Each relationship is emblematic of this disintegration, showing the protagonist's and thus her entourage's inability to make real bonds in a world characterised by indifference, commodification, and narcissism.

The protagonist's dysfunctional relation with her parents, especially her mother, embodies this shallowness from the start, antecedent to their deaths and framing her growth, or lack thereof, in isolation thereafter. She admits to a profound mutual ignorance about each other, where none of them cared to actually know about the other, creating an emotional gulf between them. Her mother is presented as a one-dimensional phantasm, as days were spent “mostly watch[ing] TV and smoke[ing] in bed all day” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 136), a passive portrayal that is reincarnated in the protagonist's subsequent withdrawal into

drugs and television. This maternal detachment, ingrained with the same media-inflected torpor that the protagonist assumes, evokes a hereditary legacy of escapism, in which human connection is eclipsed by solitary consumption. Her father, by contrast, flaunts a different but no less distancing superficiality, which she observes: “he was much more comfortable around his students than with me or my mother” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 137). His choice of academic acolytes over family closeness underscores a performative persona, more professor than parent, even at his funeral, which she describes as “a real production. There were printed programs, long speeches” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 141). This overt performance turns mourning into a manufactured spectacle without any real sorrow, in which the protagonist's identity as a grieving daughter feels more performative than visceral, trapping them in the shallowness of their bond.

It would be quite unfair to analyse the protagonist from simply a passive perspective. Following her parents' deaths, she tried therapy as a solution to refine her life and treat her existential dilemma, which later proved to be inefficacious. Far from providing therapeutic sanctuary, Dr. Tuttle hands out prescriptions with extreme nonchalance and negligence, as the protagonist muses, “she gave me everything I asked for, and I appreciated her for that” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 25), often responds to the protagonist's ennui and quandary with inanity. Their exchanges and appointments are marked by void conversation and aloofness, condensed to a mechanical transaction exchanging pills for money, a noticeable dynamic where the protagonist observes that she pays Dr. Tuttle to make her feel good, comparing her to a prostitute

feeding her lullabies. Diminished of any genuine concern, this relationship mimics the commodified superficiality of the broader culture, where “bonds and partnerships tend to be viewed and treated as things meant to be consumed, not produced” (Bauman, 2000, p. 163). Thus, human connectedness plays a role in an ultimate personal end, in this case, the protagonist’s quest for chemical enervation and Dr. Tuttler for monetary purposes. The absurdity of Dr. Tuttle misdiagnosing ailments, droning on in a coalescence of wrong prescriptions, further hollows out the therapeutic bond, making it a grotesque simulacrum of healing, a commentary on a society in which even humanity is centred around mutual profit.

The closest thing to intimacy and authenticity in the novel is illustrated through the complex relationship between the protagonist and her friend Reva, oscillating between camaraderie and contempt. Admittedly, the protagonist recognises that her friendship with Reva is nonsensical, noting, “we’d been friends since college, long enough that all we had left in common was our history together, a complex circuit of resentment, memory, jealousy, denial” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 7). She resents Reva’s enslavement to vanity and social status, a critique steeped in hypocrisy given that she is the ultimate epitome of the white privileged narcissist. Even in a tragic situation where empathy is required and consolation is expected, such as when Reva’s mother gets diagnosed with cancer and undergoes chemotherapy, a disease that killed the protagonist’s father, she belittles and dismisses Reva’s sadness, urging her to quit being needy (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 17). On the other hand, Reva’s jealousy is revealed through her recurrent “not fair” mantra, a catchphrase that secures its position all

throughout the novel. The protagonist voices, “[Reva] saw my struggle with misery as a cruel parody of her own misfortunes...[and] took some satisfaction in watching me crumble into the ineffectual slob she hoped I was becoming” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 14). However, the complexity of their friendship is not secluded to mutual hatred; Reva constantly urges the protagonist to quit using drugs, a trepidation rooted in profound care and affection. Similarly, following the death of Reva’s mother, the protagonist travels to console Reva, and in a drugged haze on the verge of sleeping, she murmurs, ““I love you, Reva,”....“I’m really sorry about your mom”” (Moshfegh, 2018, p. 177), a rare flicker of emotion in this liminal state where the protagonist shows any sort of feeling. Thus, Moshfegh creates a collage of relational misery in which the protagonist’s relationships reflect the fractured, empty society she lives in. This shallowness stretches beyond lifestyle and into the very essence of human relationships, which offer no authentic refuge, only the illusion of connection amidst pervasive alienation.

4. CONCLUSION

My Year of Rest and Relaxation is a searing satire of a postmodern society stuck in the double snares of media overload and the culture of immediacy. Across the protagonist’s struggle to obliterate reality with psycho-pharmaceuticals and television, Ottessa Moshfegh lays bare a universe rotted by an endless barrage of hyperreal simulacra and commodified pathways to nowhere, echoing Postman’s warning of a society addicted to entertainment and gratification. Hyperreality, as laid out by Jean Baudrillard, and consumerist syndrome as defined by Zygmunt Bauman explain the way the characters become trapped within a

mediascape that erases depth, as the protagonist retreats into sedation and the desperate assimilation of Reva to shallow standards. Their fractured relationships are further indications of this hollow culture, where even intimacy is a performative shadow, played out rather than lived. It is a bitter irony that these characters are constantly pursuing escape through any means available – screens, pills, status – and each time they do, the path only burrows them deeper into an existential void, a vacuum of meaning, of fulfilment, that points back toward the limitation of a world where there is an abundance of gratifications, yet none of it can be sustained.

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